Baby feeding in an emergency

From BabyReady · Reviewed by Joshua West, RD

When the power or water goes out, your baby still needs to eat safely every few hours. This short guide covers what to do for babies and toddlers in the first days of an emergency, based on CDC, FDA and American Academy of Pediatrics guidance. Keep a printed copy with your kit.

If you breastfeed: keep going

Breastfeeding is the safest way to feed a baby in a disaster. It needs no water, no power and no cleaning.

- **Stress doesn't stop your milk.** Your body keeps making it; stress can slow letdown, so find a calm spot and give it a few minutes.
- **Feed more often** if you also use formula. It helps your supply and stretches your formula.
- **Learn hand expression now.** An electric pump won't work in an outage; a manual pump is in your kit.
- **Stay with your baby** so feeding isn't interrupted.
- **Keep your backup formula** (the 3-day supply on your list) in case you get sick or have trouble feeding.

If you use formula

Ready-to-feed formula is the safest choice in an emergency: no water, no mixing, single-use bottles.

Mixing powder:

1. Wash your hands, or use hand sanitizer with at least 60% alcohol.
2. Use bottled water. No bottled water? Boil water for 1 minute and let it cool.
3. Pour the water first, then add the powder with the can's scoop. Use the exact amounts on the label.
4. Cap and shake. No need to warm it; never use a microwave.

Timing: Feed within 1 hour of starting and within 2 hours of mixing. With no fridge, mix fresh for each feeding and throw away what's left.

Never:

- Add extra water to stretch formula.
- Make formula at home (FDA advises against it).
- Give cow's milk, toddler drinks or plant milks to a baby under 12 months.

If your baby was born early, is under 2 months or has a weak immune system, ask your pediatrician about extra precautions with powdered formula. Throw away cans that are dented, rusted, puffy or were in floodwater.

How long it keeps

Room temperature means 77°F or cooler. In an outage, plan on the room-temperature column: open or mix only what your baby will finish.

Breast milk

Kind	Where	How long
Freshly pumped	Room temperature	Up to 4 hours
	Cooler with frozen ice packs	Up to 24 hours
	Fridge	Up to 4 days
	Freezer	Best by 6 months, OK to 12
Thawed	Room temperature	Within 2 hours
	Fridge	Within 24 hours of fully thawing
	Freezer	Never refreeze
Left after a feeding	Anywhere	Within 2 hours, then throw away

Formula

Kind	Where	How long
Mixed from powder	Room temperature	2 hours from mixing; 1 hour once feeding starts
	Fridge	Within 24 hours

Kind	Where	How long
Ready-to-feed, opened	Room temperature	1 hour once feeding starts
	Fridge (big bottles)	Follow the label; most say 48 hours
Left in the bottle	Anywhere	Throw away
Powder can, opened	Cool, dry place, lid tight	1 month (check the label); not in the fridge

Don't freeze formula.

Baby food jars and pouches, opened

Kind	Where	How long
Any	Room temperature	Up to 2 hours
Fruits and vegetables	Fridge	2 to 3 days
	Freezer	6 to 8 months
Meats and eggs	Fridge	1 day
	Freezer	1 to 2 months
Meat and vegetable mixes	Fridge	1 to 2 days
	Freezer	1 to 2 months

- **Pro tip:** keep a couple of ice packs in your freezer and an insulated lunch bag with your kit. If the power goes out, pumped milk stays safe up to 24 hours.
- **Thawing:** thaw the oldest milk first, in the fridge or in lukewarm water, never in a microwave.
- **Jars and pouches:** spoon what you need into a bowl. If your baby eats straight from the jar or pouch, saliva gets in, so throw away the rest after that meal.

When you can't wash bottles: use a cup

If you don't have safe water to clean a bottle and nipple, feed breast milk or formula from a small disposable cup and throw the cup away after.

1. Hold your baby upright, close to your body, with the head supported.
2. Fill the cup about two-thirds full and rest its rim on the lower lip.
3. Tilt just until the milk touches the lips and let your baby sip or lap. Never pour it in.
4. Go slowly, pause for burps, and stop when your baby turns away or closes their mouth.

With safe water, wash bottles with soap and a little water (one small drop of dish soap is enough). Throw away nipples and pacifiers that touched floodwater.

Solids, water and toddlers

- **Under 6 months:** breast milk or formula only. No water, juice or solids.
- **6 to 12 months:** keep milk feeds first. Offer purees and soft foods your baby already eats, plus small sips of safe water. An emergency isn't the time to try new foods.
- **12 months and up:** whole cow's milk (shelf-stable boxes keep without a fridge) plus regular foods. Switch to low-fat milk at age 2.
- **Under 4: prevent choking.** Skip nuts and seeds, popcorn, chips, meat sticks, chunks of meat or cheese, whole grapes and raw apple or carrot. Spread seed or nut butter thinly.
- **Wash hands** before every meal, or use 60% alcohol sanitizer. Opened baby food keeps 2 hours without a fridge (see How long it keeps).

Call the pediatrician right away if you see

- Fewer than 6 wet diapers a day, or peeing only once or twice
- A dry mouth, or few or no tears when crying
- A sunken soft spot on the head, or sunken eyes
- Unusual sleepiness, or fussiness you can't settle
- Cool, blotchy hands and feet

If you can't reach your doctor and your child seems very sick, call 911.

Not medical advice. Ask your pediatrician about your child's needs and any medicine doses. Reviewed by Joshua West, RD.

Sources

- CDC: Feeding your child safely during a disaster
- CDC: Questions about infant feeding in emergencies
- CDC: Prepare and store powdered infant formula in an emergency
- CDC: Cup feeding infants during emergencies
- FDA: Questions and answers for consumers about infant formula
- AAP HealthyChildren: Recommended drinks for children ages 0 to 5
- AAP HealthyChildren: Choking prevention
- AAP HealthyChildren: Dehydration
- CDC: Proper storage and preparation of breast milk
- CDC: Infant formula preparation and storage
- Baby food storage chart, adapted from FDA (via NDSU Extension)